



HIGHWAY 1 between Lucia and Lime Creek had been closed for three years to repair the Regent's Slide.

Scenic route through Big Sur reopens

Closed by storm damage and slides for three years, Highway 1 is fixed and fully back.

By Grace Toohey

First, it was a series of strong atmospheric rivers that set off a troublesome landslide in January 2023, again splitting up the world-famous drive along Big Sur's iconic coastline.

Then, a second winter of drenching storms triggered two more slides, including one that buried another section of California's Highway 1 under 300,000 cubic yards of dirt, rock and debris.

To make matters worse, weeks later Mother Nature appeared to take a bite out of a cliffside lane near the Rocky Creek Bridge.

But now, for the first time in three years, the coastal two-lane highway is completely open for an uninterrupted drive of the roughly 100 miles between Carmel and Cambria.

"This vital corridor is the gateway to California's coast and the lifeblood of the Big Sur economy — and today it's restored," Gov. Gavin Newsom said in a statement Wednesday announcing the reopening. He thanked crews for helping pull off the early completion of extensive repair work that the California Department of Transportation had initially estimated wouldn't be finished until March.

"This will be a return to normalcy," said Ryne Leuzinger, chair of the board of directors for the Big Sur Community Assn., calling the reopening a reunification of north and south Big Sur and a much-needed boost for local businesses. "2026 will be a really nice time to visit Big Sur."

Despite several closures at different locations throughout the last three years, the last stretch of the highway that remained closed was a remote, 6.8-mile span from just north of Lucia until about a mile south of the Esalen Institute, according to Caltrans.

Officials had been working to finalize repairs in that area, known as Regent's Slide, which is part of a particularly steep section of the coastline that faces persistent pressure from an unrelenting ocean and harsh weather.

While closures are a recurring feature of life in Big Sur — routinely forcing bedeviling drivers to detour inland on Highway 101 or even the 5 Freeway — this was the longest stretch of time in recent history that

[See Reopening, A6]

Danish envoys reject U.S. threat to seize Greenland

Trump cites national security concerns, but Arctic territory seeks stronger ties instead.

By Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — Top Danish diplomats met with White House officials on Wednesday to talk about President Trump's repeated threats to take control of Greenland and left with the understanding that the United States and Denmark have a "fundamental disagreement" about the future of the Arctic territory.

Lars Lokke Rasmussen, the Danish foreign minister, told reporters that the closed-door meeting with Vice President JD Vance and Secretary of State Marco

Rubio had been "frank, but also constructive," and that he was hopeful the allied governments would be able to find a "common way forward" in the near future.

"For us, ideas that would not respect territorial integrity of the Kingdom of Denmark and the right of self-determination of the Greenlandic people are, of course, totally unacceptable," Lokke Rasmussen said. "We, therefore, still have a fundamental disagreement, but we also agree to disagree."

In the hours leading up to the meeting, Trump said in a social media post that the "United States needs Greenland" for national security purposes — and that "anything less than" acquiring the Danish territory would be "unacceptable." Otherwise, the president has argued, China or Russia will

annex the territory because he does not think Danish officials have done enough to protect the island.

As Vance and Rubio met with the Danish officials, the White House posted a cartoon on social media that depicted two dog sleds, with Greenland's flag on the back, facing two pathways: a sunny day at the White House or a stormy scenario with Chinese and Russian flags. The image did not show a pathway with Denmark.

Vivian Motzfeldt, Greenland's foreign minister, told reporters after the meeting that she wants to strengthen the island's ties with the United States. But she asserted: "That doesn't mean that we want to be owned by the United States."

The meeting marked the

[See Greenland, A6]

State targets xAI's explicit deepfakes

Newsom calls for scrutiny of Musk firm, alleging a 'breeding ground for predators.'

By Melody Gutierrez

SACRAMENTO — California announced an investigation Wednesday into Elon Musk's xAI, with Gov. Gavin Newsom accusing the artificial intelligence company of becoming a "breeding ground for predators to spread nonconsensual sexually explicit AI deepfakes."

Grok, the xAI chatbot, in-

cludes image-generation features that allow users to morph existing photos into new images. The newly created images are then posted publicly on X.

Critics say there are not sufficient safeguards on what images can be generated, prompting an influx of sexually explicit or nonconsensual images based on real people, including altered depictions that appear to show individuals partially or fully undressed. Others have generated images that appear to show minors, prompting criticism that the tools are being used to create child pornography.

The social media site has previously said, "We take action against illegal content on X, including Child Sexual Abuse Material (CSAM), by removing it, permanently suspending accounts, and working with local governments and law enforcement as necessary."

This month, Grok started limiting the ability for nonpaying users to create sexualized images amid a global outcry from users and governments.

Newsom called the images being created "vile." State Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta said his office will use "all tools at our disposal to keep

Court upholds Proposition 50 map of districts

Judges reject idea that the new lines drawn to bolster Democrats were race-based.

By Jenny Jarvie

In a major victory for Gov. Gavin Newsom and the Democratic Party, a federal court in Los Angeles ruled Wednesday that California can use its newly configured congressional district boundaries for the 2026 midterm elections, increasing Democrats' odds of winning five additional U.S. House seats and seizing control of the chamber.

Attorneys for the GOP had sought to temporarily block California's new map, arguing that the redrawn districts — placed on the ballot in November by the Democratic-led state Legislature as Proposition 50 — were unconstitutional because they illegally favored Latino voters.

But two judges in a three-judge panel rejected Republican arguments. The maps, they found, were engineered by Democrats to favor their party's candidates and counter similar partisan gerrymandering from Texas and other GOP-led states.

"The evidence presented reflects that Proposition 50 was exactly what it was billed as: a political gerrymander designed to flip five Republican-held seats to the Democrats," U.S. District Judge Josephine L. Staton wrote in an opinion.

Whatever the intent of those who drew up the maps, Staton added, "the voters are the most relevant state actors and their intent is paramount."

Staton, who was appointed by President Obama, was joined by District Judge Wesley Hsu, an appointee of President Biden. Judge Kenneth K. Lee of the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals, an appointee of President Trump, dissented.

Lee argued that public comments made by Paul Mitchell, the redistricting expert who drew up the new California map, showed race was a key factor.

"The Democratic supermajority in the California state legislature wanted to curry favor with Latino groups and voters — and to prevent Latino voters from drifting away from the party," Lee wrote in his dissent.

The California Republican Party said it would seek

[See Districts, A7]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

USING the new map could boost Gov. Gavin Newsom's profile as he weighs a 2028 presidential run.

Wall St. is warning Trump on Fed attack

The president's push against central bank and credit card issuers is souring relationship.

By Ken Sweet

Up until this week, Wall Street has generally benefited from the Trump administration's policies and has been supportive of the president. That relationship has suddenly soured.

When President Trump signed the One Big Beautiful Bill Act into law in July, it pushed another significant round of tax cuts and also cut the budget of the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau, at times the banking industry's nemesis, by nearly half. Trump's bank regulators have also been pushing a deregulatory agenda that both banks and large corporations have embraced.

But now the president has proposed a one-year, 10% cap on the interest rate on credit cards, a lucrative business for many financial institutions, and his Department of Justice has launched an investigation into Federal Reserve Chair Jerome H. Powell that many say threatens the institution that is supposed to set interest rates free of political interference.

Bank chief executives warned the White House on Tuesday that Trump's actions will do more harm than good to the American economy. But in response, Trump did not back down on his

[See Wall Street, A11]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

BEETLES ON THE MARCH

A man in Orange County uses limewash to fight tree-killing goldspotted oak borers, which have now spread into Ventura County. **SCIENCE, A8**

Galaxy's Edge changes course

"Star Wars" area at Disneyland shifts from original ambitions to spotlight "classic" characters. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Very warm. L.A. Basin: 86/53. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Do theater chiefs make the grade?

How Geffen Playhouse, CTG and Pasadena Playhouse leaders fare. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

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